Pilot Licence (CPL)-holder has been trained single-pilot, largely visual, on a light piston aircraft, in uncongested airspace," says Khushbeg Jattana, general manager, Simaero India, an arm of the French company Simaero that operates a pilot training and simulation facility in Delhi-NCR. "That is exactly why India's airlines default to recruiting pilots already type-rated (a pilot's specialisation in a type of aircraft and the licence to fly that) and why that supply gets sourced globally. It is a rational commercial decision by an airline, and a structural failure of the pipeline."

For Manoj Chacko, founder and CEO of regional carrier FLY91, building indigenous capability in pilot, aircraft engineer and technician training is just as important as building airports and airlines. "Equally important is who delivers that training," he says. "For too long, parts of the ecosystem have been left to fragmented, mom-and-pop-type operators. To become a global aviation powerhouse, aviation training must be built on quality, safety and scale, and a regulatory framework that encourages modern learning."

THE RANKING TEST

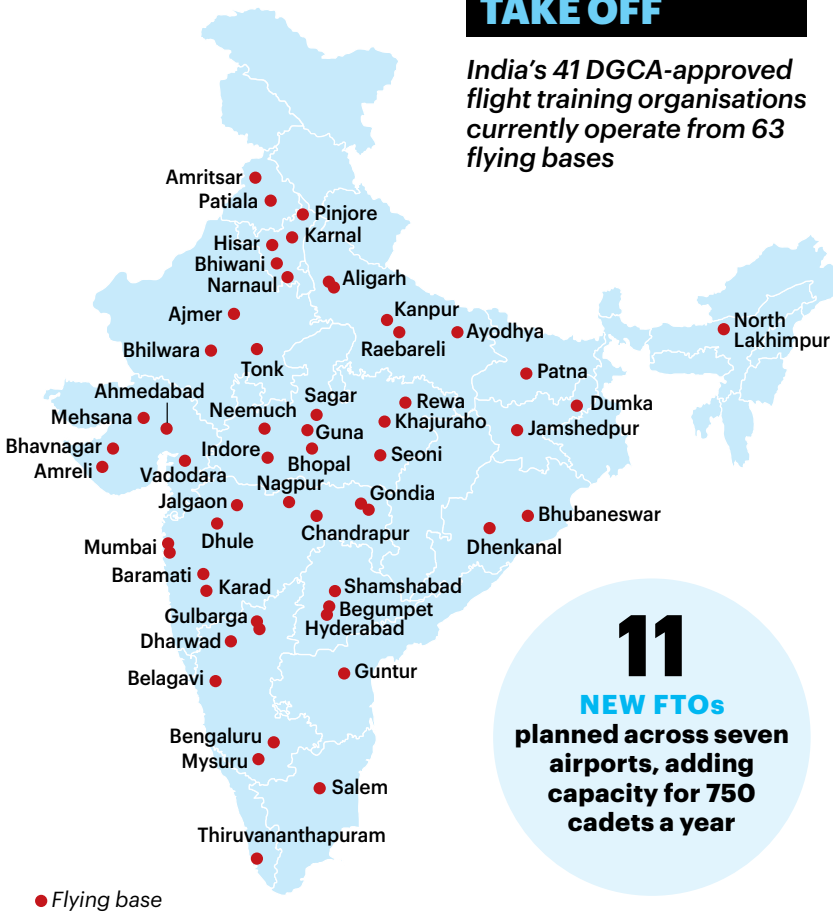
There is little dispute over the need for creating a benchmark for pilot training in India. However, the so-called report card, if industry opinion is to be believed, has caused a lot of heartburn even before take-off.

The Association of Flying Training Organisations (AFTO), a collective of the 41-odd DGCA-approved flying schools, has challenged the system and the data upon which the exercise is based, as well as the concept of a 'regulator ranking organisations it regulates'. Industry officials say they were merely informed of the ranking exercise being introduced, with little opportunity for substantive consultation.

Of the 35 FTOs ranked in October 2025, none got an A+ or A, 13 were rated B, and 22—or nearly two-thirds—were rated C. Among the top three were Chimes Aviation Academy with air bases in Madhya Pradesh,

WHERE CADETS TAKE OFF

India's 41 DGCA-approved flight training organisations currently operate from 63 flying bases



11
NEW FTOs planned across seven airports, adding capacity for 750 cadets a year



"Wrong data can impact multiple parameters in the scoring process. So if you lose 20-30 marks due to this out of a possible 80, then nobody will qualify"

D.P. HEMANTH
CEO, Asia Pacific Flight Training Academy, Telangana & Karnataka

SVKM's NMIMS Academy of Aviation at Shirpur, Maharashtra, and Bihar Flying Club, Patna. The civil aviation ministry's own FTO, Indira Gandhi Rashtriya Uran Akademi (IGRUA) in Amethi, stood 25th with a C category.

Those rankings stood revised in the second round. Avyanna Aviation Academy in Rajasthan's Kishangarh became the first FTO ever to achieve a category A rating. Chimes, among the top three in Round 1, slipped to 10th position while retaining its B category in the previous round. Eleven schools upgraded their ratings from C to B, including the ministry's FTO. However, seven existing FTOs slipped from B to C. Such movement is precisely what the government hopes to achieve: set a baseline, identify weaknesses and push schools to improve. According to official data, utilisation of training fly-